The Map That Came Home

Lark & Nib's Treasure Quest · Season 1, Episode 9

For the first time, nothing was missing from the explorer case. The original map and all four recovered sections lay inside. Nib counted them twice, using the tip of one careful paw.

“A whole map,” Nib declared hopefully. “Some assembly required.”

The clearing was broad and dry. Nib braced the umbrella over the work spot. Lark fixed the little sail as a windbreak, with the sand sack holding its support low against the ground. They had brought their shelter with them in pieces, too.

Two matching folios rested in the wagon. Their labels faced outward.

“Read the word on the paper cover,” Lark invited gently. “Choose map rather than mat. Look all the way to the last letter.”

Lark spread the picnic mat herself. It made a soft, flat surface under the umbrella. Then she opened the chosen folio and laid its stiff backing on top.

The orchard section met the original. The ridge section continued its path. The island section joined neatly beside it. Each little road led into the next.

The meadow piece did not.

Lark turned it one way, then the other. Its edge was too short. A path ended in empty space.

“Perhaps there is one more piece,” Lark whispered anxiously.

Nib leaned close. Along one edge, the paper looked twice as thick.

“Perhaps there is one more fold,” Nib suggested carefully.

Lark stopped moving it. On the underside, a small flap had been tucked back along an old crease. No new cache was needed. The last connection was hiding against the paper they already had.

“Let's look at that doubled edge,” Lark invited gently. “Open the fold slowly, so we can see the whole drawing.”

The flap unfolded. Its little road continued the island path and curved around the crooked root. The edges fitted.

Nib let out a breath that made his scarf move.

“A very small fold,” Nib murmured appreciatively. “A very large difference.”

Lark brought the tool kit. Two pockets had familiar labels, pin and pan.

“We need the little clips,” Lark reminded you softly. “Read both pocket labels. Which one tells us where to find them? Listen to the middle if you need help.”

She used the spare clips to hold the edges against the stiff backing. No clip pressed on a fragile line. The joined paper stayed flat when Nib moved his paws away.

The moonstone rested in Lark's wing. Its amber light spread across the complete map. Hidden ink appeared along one continuous route: orchard, ridge, river, island, meadow.

Then the line curved back to a treehouse.

Lark stared.

“We came all this way to come home?” Lark asked, bewildered.

Nib turned the drawing until its crooked root pointed toward the oak in your first journal picture. Above the root, the branch divided in two.

“Perhaps we have not looked at all of home,” Nib murmured thoughtfully.

Lark opened the journal beside the map. The oak at camp was drawn from the front. The tree on the map was drawn from behind. The root and forked branch were the same shapes seen from different sides.

“Which tree in our journal has both these features?” Lark asked gently. “Use the root and the branch together. What does that tell us about where the route ends?”

The familiar tree suddenly seemed full of unfamiliar possibilities.

Lark drew the unfolded corner on your ninth page. Beside it she left space for a useful old word.

“Write map beside today's picture,” Lark invited warmly. “You can use our folio label to help with m, a, and p.”

Nib folded the sail and umbrella. The sand sack returned low in the wagon, the mat went into its own folio, and the complete map traveled flat on its backing. This time all its roads stayed together.

By evening, the wagon rested beneath the camp oak. Your treehouse stood above the familiar front steps. Beyond the crooked root, a narrow ground-level path curved around the trunk.

Lark looked along it, then closed the case carefully.

“Our map is finished,” Lark breathed wonderingly. “Tomorrow we can look at the other side.”

Nib settled beside the wheel.

“Home,” Nib murmured contentedly. “With a remarkably promising back.”